

8.1 Masks And Alpha Channels

We already know that images are made up of three channels—Red, Green and Blue. But every once in a while, you will hear the words “Alpha” or “Alpha Channel” used in the context of digital imagery.

What are Alpha channels?

All channels are greyscale images that basically represent the intensity of that particular colour. For example, white areas in a Red Channel mean that those areas have full (100 per cent) red intensity. Similarly, black areas mean that those areas have no red in them.

The Alpha channel, too, behaves this way, only instead of colour, it represents *transparency*, or rather, the presence of the image itself. So black areas in an alpha channel mean that the image is fully transparent (or not there) in those areas, while the image will show through the white areas. When you create a mask for a layer, you’re actually creating an Alpha channel for it.

Why Masks?

A good deal of what can be accomplished by using masks is also possible with a few well-made selections here and there, so why use them?

Well, for one thing, masks are treated just the same as any other layer—any effect you can apply to a layer can also be applied to the mask, giving you the ability to create some incredible effects that would take days to accomplish with just selections. Moreover, masks allow for completely non-destructive editing—that is, you



The black part in the layer mask lets the underlying image show through